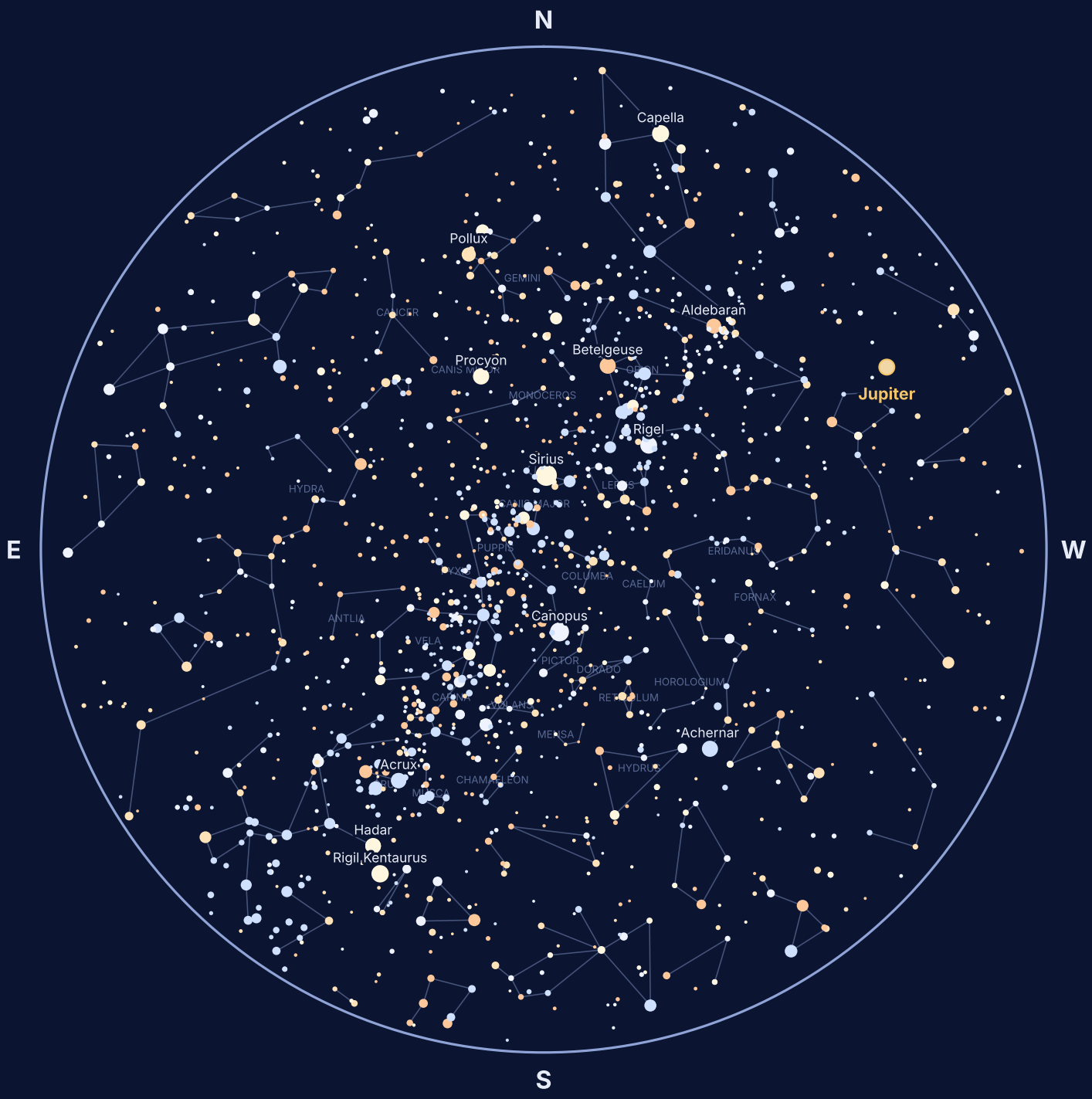
Remembering Grandad Joe

Sydney · Saturday 02 March 2024 · 21:00



The sky above Sydney, latitude -33.87°, longitude 151.21°

With love, from the sky.

A letter from the sky

This is a letter from the sky. It's about one night: Saturday, the second of March, twenty twenty-four, in Sydney. It was a night we remember Grandad Joe.

Nobody photographs the sky on nights like that. Everyone is looking somewhere else. So here is what was happening above you, worked out from the movements of the Earth, the Moon and the planets.

The Sun had set at half past seven in the evening. By five to nine in the evening the last of the twilight had gone.

The Moon was waning gibbous, six tenths lit. It hadn't risen yet. It would come up in the east at ten to eleven at night.

The planets were out too. Jupiter was a little way up in the north-west. Jupiter is a giant planet with a storm called the Great Red Spot, bigger than the whole Earth.

Before dawn, Venus and Mars would rise as well.

Among the stars, Sirius was very high in the north. The light from Sirius that shone on Sydney that night had left the star around twenty fifteen. Canopus was very high in the south. The light from Canopus that shone on Sydney that night had left the star around seventeen eleven. Rigel was very high in the north-west. The light from Rigel that shone on Sydney that night had left the star around twelve fifty-one.

Directly overhead was the constellation of Canis Major. Canis Major is one of the eighty-eight constellations, the star patterns people have used for thousands of years to find their way around the sky. The sky will never be arranged in exactly this way again. The Moon, the planets and the turning Earth will not line up like this for thousands of years.

But every year, around March, the same stars come back to the same places in the evening sky. So when you look up and find Sirius, you are looking at the sky of that night. With love, from the sky.